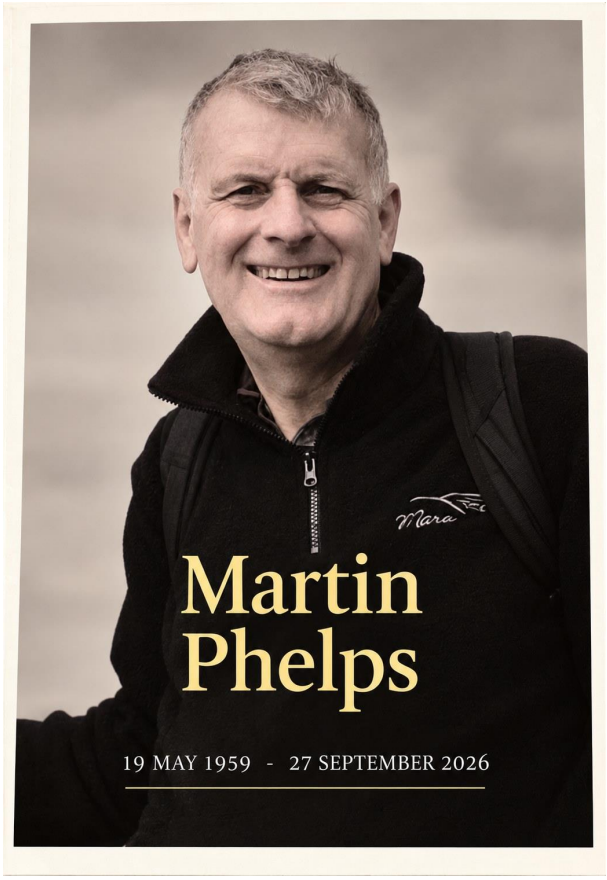
San Fairy Ann Cycling Club Newsletter October 2026

Creator Lorna Stafford

The Funeral of Martin Phelps



A really sad occasion on a wet, dull October day, but what a wonderful send-off for Martin at Tunbridge Wells Crematorium.

So many people attended, including around 20 members of San Fairy Ann Cycling Club. The service was so well attended that many had to watch from the entrance. Martin's cycling cap was placed on his coffin, a fitting tribute to his love of cycling and the club.

The humanist ceremony celebrated so many of Martin's lifetime achievements, his cycling world and his many other interests. His daughters shared poignant and humorous memories, giving everyone a lovely insight into Martin's very close family life.

Afterwards, his wife and daughters hosted a wonderful wake at Hotel du Vin, where many fond memories were shared among those who had the pleasure of knowing Martin at different times in their lives.

By Richard Valentine

Update on the Christmas Party.



Christmas Party Friday 27th November – Don't Miss Out!

The countdown is on! **Thursday, November 12th is your last chance** to pay for your Christmas party sit-down meal or buffet before the club shop closes.

A huge thank you to all the members and partners who have already paid. The numbers are looking amazing, and it's shaping up to be a fantastic night!

We'll have our own exclusive area at The Ridge Golf Club, and, of course, our very own club band will be back to get the party going!

More details on timings will follow next week, but one thing's for sure – it's going to be a great evening.

And remember, this party is for ALL SFA members, so come along and join the fun. The more, the merrier!

The link to pay for either the sit-down dinner or the buffet is live. Of course, partners are very much welcome.

Pay Here

The Bull Meet-Up – A Good Start!

Our first Wednesday winter meet-up took place at The Bull in Penenden Heath, with around a dozen members turning up for the inaugural get-together.

After a little confusion over which room we'd been allocated (thank you, Jenny, for sorting that out pronto!), we soon settled down with a drink and plenty of chat.

The plan is to move the meet-up between different pubs in the New Year, giving members from across the club a chance to join in. We're also hoping that, if there's enough interest, we can arrange the occasional guest speaker to add something extra to the evenings.

A big thank you to everyone who made the effort to come along. It was a great start, and hopefully we'll see even more faces next time!

Save the dates!

Our meet-ups take place on the second Wednesday of every month, from 7.30 pm.

- **Wednesday 11th November**
- **Wednesday 9th December**

Next venue: The Bull PH

Boxley Road, Penenden Heath, Maidstone, ME14 2DH.

We've reserved the private room to the left of the main bar.

Come along – we'd love to see you there!

You don't need to know anyone or come with a group. These evenings are a great opportunity to meet other club members, catch up with familiar faces and make some new

cycling friends. Whether you've been a member for years or have only recently joined, everyone is welcome.

So put the dates in your diary, pop in for a drink and a chat, and help us make these winter get-togethers a regular club favourite!

Winter Workshop – Is Your Bike Ready?



Winter is coming, and your bike deserves a little TLC before the salt and grit take their toll!

On the 21st, Lorna hosted a Ladies' Bike Maintenance Workshop in Marden, sharing practical advice on keeping our bikes in good shape throughout the winter months.

The session covered the importance of protecting your bike from winter grime, the different types of lubricants and when to use them, plus how to choose the right tyre pressures for wet and slippery conditions.

Unfortunately, numbers were lower than hoped, which is a shame because these workshops offer excellent value. Similar sessions in the private sector would typically cost £35–£50 for 2.5 hours, whereas SFA members paid just £10!

Those who attended thoroughly enjoyed the session and came away feeling they'd gained a lot of knowledge. We'll be looking at how to encourage more members to get involved in future workshops.

A little knowledge can save a lot of money and keep your bike running smoothly all winter. Don't miss out next time!

Riding Through Autumn & Winter – Be Prepared!



Who says cycling stops when summer ends? There's something special about crisp winter mornings, quiet country lanes and that well-earned café stop after a chilly ride. But shorter days, colder temperatures and wet roads mean it's time to change our approach. With the right preparation, winter cycling can be hugely rewarding – so before you head out, here's how to get yourself and your bike ready for the months ahead.

🚲 Bike Preparation

- Fit mudguards to protect yourself and fellow riders from road spray.
- Check front and rear lights, and keep batteries fully charged. Cold weather can drain them faster.
- Clean and wipe down your bike after winter rides, paying particular attention to the drivetrain. Lubricate your chain regularly.

Top tip: A well-maintained bike will give you years of enjoyment.

🎒 What to Wear

- Start with a moisture-wicking base layer to keep sweat away from your skin.
- Add an insulating mid-layer, with removable arm and leg warmers for changeable conditions.
- Finish with a windproof gilet or winter jacket, depending on the temperature.
- Wear lightweight windproof gloves, plus a neck buff or skull cap under your helmet.

Top tip: Dress so you feel slightly chilly when you first set off. If you're warm standing still, you'll probably overheat once you get going.

🍌 Food & Hydration

- Colder weather and stronger winds can increase energy demands, so keep fuelling up.
- Don't skip the café stop! Something warm to eat or drink can make all the difference.

- Energy bars can become very hard in the cold. Keep softer bars or flapjacks in an inside pocket so they stay edible.
- Don't forget to drink. You may feel less thirsty, but you're still losing fluids. Consider electrolytes or a warm drink in a flask.
- Have a protein-rich recovery snack or meal within 30–45 minutes after you finish your ride.

Top tip: A hot shower, something nourishing to eat and a good night's sleep are all part of recovering properly.

The message is simple: wrap up, fuel up, look after your bike and keep riding. Winter cycling can be just as enjoyable as summer – provided you're prepared!

By Jane Pilbeam.

SFA Goes Cross! The Cyclocross Season Gets Underway









SFA Goes Cross! The Cyclocross Season Gets Underway

While many of us were still enjoying the tail end of summer, a few SFA members had already swapped their road bikes for something a little more adventurous. The cyclocross season is underway, and there's been no shortage of mud-free dust, technical challenges and racing action so far!

Brighton – A Tough Start

The opening round of the London & South East League took place in Brighton on 6th September. Simon Charlesworth and I lined up for our first battle of the season on a course

that was baked hard and covered in dust. With temperatures still in the mid-20s, it hardly felt like the start of an autumn sport!

A whopping 67 riders set off together across three categories, making the opening laps particularly congested. Simon produced an excellent ride to finish **6th out of 15 in M60**. Even more impressive, given he started from the back row after missing the previous season.

My race was rather more eventful. A bit of a coming together on the opening lap left me with a broken spoke and a misaligned shifter. Not exactly the ideal start! Nevertheless, I battled on to finish **31st out of 50 in M50**.

East Kent – Tommy and Louis Join the Action

Next up was the East Kent CX League, where regular SFA road racers Tommy and Louis took on the senior category. The fast, flat course suited them well, particularly in the dry conditions, and they came away with very respectable finishes of **9th and 13th** respectively.

Pippingford – Getting Into My Stride

Round 2 of the London & South East League took us to Pippingford, on the Kent/Sussex border. This time, I avoided any mechanical mishaps or opening-lap drama and improved to **22nd out of 51**. Things were looking up!

Crystal Palace – A Technical Challenge

At Round 3, Phil Hoffman joined me on the start line at Crystal Palace. Still recovering from a broken collarbone sustained on a training ride, Phil put in a gallant performance, finishing **11th out of 14 in M60**.

This was my favourite course so far. Plenty of technical challenges, including planks, off-camber sections and some seriously fast descents. Just the sort of course that keeps you on your toes! I finished **28th out of 56**.

Herne Hill – Sharp Elbows Required!

The latest round took us to the famous Herne Hill Velodrome. More familiar territory for the trackies among us, perhaps, but somehow they manage to squeeze a cyclocross course into the venue too!

Space was at a premium, and the first half of the race was extremely tight and overcrowded. You certainly needed your sharp elbows! Fortunately, things opened up as the field thinned out, making the second half much more enjoyable. I finished **22nd again, out of 57 riders**.

Fancy Having a Go?

The next race is Round 2 of the East Kent CX League at Dover on the 18th. These events cater for all ages and abilities, with racing throughout the day, starting with the Under-8s and going right through to Masters 70.

There's also a fantastic opportunity for newcomers with the East Kent League's **'Try CX'** event. Designed specifically for absolute beginners, it features a slightly shorter course with the more challenging obstacles removed. It's an ideal way to find out what cyclocross is all about without being thrown in at the deep end!

If you've ever fancied trying something different, why not give it a go? I'm more than happy to answer questions and help anyone interested in getting started.

By Steven Pope

Dunkirk to Ypres ride arranged by Richard Barsley, 16th-21st September.



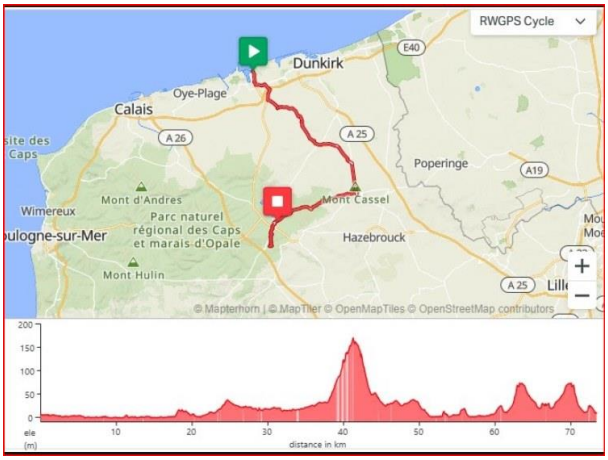
1 - Day 1 during a dry spell.jpg



2 - The Christmas football match site Mesen Belgium.jpg



3 - Russel on quiet roads near Carency, France.jpg



4 - Day 1 showing the climb into Cassel.jpg



5 - The Coupole St Omer.jpg



6 - The Menin Gate, Ypres.jpg



7 - The Peloton cycling through Belgium.jpg



8 - The team at Caterpillar Crater Ypres.jpg



9 - Ypres Cloth Hall Belgium.jpg

Once again, I was delighted to join Richard Barsley for his fantastically well-organised trip to France. This was my third outing with him, and it was another superb trip. The ride took place from 7th to 14 September.

This year the group consisted of SFA members Richard, Charles Barsley, Russell Chidick and friends Paul and Alice Robinson. Five riders and Alice, who did an amazing job as support driver.

We met on Tuesday evening in Dover and were up at the slightly uncivilised hour of 3.30 am to check in and catch the first ferry to Dunkirk.

Richard put together a great ride itinerary, travelling from Dunkirk down to Arras, back up to Ypres, and finally back to Dunkirk over 5 days. Along the way, we would visit a host of mainly WW1 historic sites, cemeteries, and places of interest. We covered between 40 and 50 miles per day, interspersed with visits to sites and coffee shops along the way. Alice supported us by carrying our luggage, driving from stop to stop, and providing a wonderful French-style picnic at lunchtime. This arrangement worked wonderfully, letting the cyclists enjoy the ride unburdened.

Day 1 Dunkirk to Saint Omer via Cassel (46 miles)

After a rainy start at Carrefour, we travelled through the flatlands of Dunkirk to Cassel. The ride up to Cassel is an interesting 1.5-mile climb, mainly over cobbles and peaking at a 19% gradient! The Ride with GPS profile hints at the day's climb. Then, with the hills fully behind us, the rain persisted; a very soggy five reached our hotel in St Omer, where we decided to postpone our last point of interest until the following day.

Along the way, we visited Esquelbecq and its church, Wormhoudt, and Le Pechot Block House.

Day 2 St Omer to Noyelles (47 miles)

Our first stop was the postponed La Coupole, an incredible concrete-engineered silo for storing and firing WW2 V2 rockets. The sinister dome lurks in a natural valley. It is reassuring to know the Second World War ended before this launch site was active, avoiding rockets raining down on London and the South East. From there we cycled in good weather and excellent roads and cycleways to Noyelles.

Day 3 – Noyelles to Lille (55 Miles)

This was a packed day of interesting visits from Noyelles down to Arras, then back North to Lille. Lille is the capital of Flanders and a big city, yet cycling is surprisingly easy thanks to considerate French drivers and a good network of cycle paths through the city. The Wellington Tunnels are a fascinating underground network of tunnels used for military purposes in both the First and Second World Wars.

Along the way, we visited the Wellington Tunnels, Arras Memorial, Albain St Nazaire ruin church, and Fromelles Pheasant Wood cemetery.

Day 4 – Lille to Ypres (37 miles)

Today we cycled through parts of France and Belgium that saw some of the deadliest fighting of the First World War. Again, we cycled on excellent roads and cycle paths. Belgian roads typically include an adjacent cycle path and are made for excellent, safe riding through the region. We made up for the lack of milage with a full itinerary of eight sites. The day ended with the daily memorial gathering at the Menin Gate in Ypres for the Last Post ceremony. Although performed daily, the memorial is always well attended, and a testament to the respect and memory of the huge casualty list suffered in the First World War.

Along the way, we visited the Ploegsteert memorial, the Irish Tower, Messines football match memorial, Hill 60 and Caterpillar Crater, Brothers in Arms, Tyne Cot-Poperinge Langemark Cemetery and Essex Farms Cemetery.

Day 5 - Ypres to Dunkirk (44 miles)

Another mainly dry day on the bike, with some points of interest, but with the thought in the back of our minds that we needed to catch a ferry home. Nine miles in, we passed through Popernghe where there had been a hop festival the day before. Judging by the

amount of hops on the road, the town seemed to have had an excellent knees-up. The roads were green with hops as we cycled through the pretty town.

And then, inevitably, we were back in Dunkirk, with only the ferry crossing before parting ways. It had been a brilliant trip with wonderful company, fabulous cycling and the inevitable sadness and emotion of comprehending the devastation of the First World War. Thanks go to Richard, who curated and organised the trip impeccably (as always). Also to Alice for supporting the riders and fuelling us through the days.

Along the way, we visited Talbot House (TocH), the Dunkirk Memorial, and the Dunkirk Museum.

I highly recommend a bike trip through Flanders. The cycling is typically safe and enjoyable, with so much to see along the way. If you would like to know more about the trip, perhaps to find ideas for your own trip, then our cycling buddy Paul's full account can be found here.

Richard Barsley, Charles Barsley, Tom Gordon, Russell Chidwick, Paul Robinson. Supported by Alice Robinson.

By Tom Gordon

THE RETURN OF RACING – AND WHAT A SEASON IT'S BEEN!







After a few years away from the racing scene, **San Fairy Ann is firmly back in the mix!** More than 25 races, some fantastic victories, podium finishes, category promotions and impressive time trial performances have put our purple and yellow colours back on the racing map.

Reuban, David, Louis, Andy, Autumn and the rest of the squad have given us plenty to celebrate. And there's more to come, with the launch of our very first women's racing team planned for 2027!

From Cyclopark to the London Nocturne, the Welsh 100 to some testing hill climbs, we've rounded up the highlights, the results and plenty of photographs.

Want to see what our racers have been up to? Click here to look back at a cracking season for San Fairy Ann**!**

By Rueban Davey

SFA club track session.24 October 2026, Lee Valley Velodrome.



Our latest club session for the Fairies at the Olympic Park velodrome in London drew 8 riders. It was the place to ride to forget the potholes and the cold, dark, very wet, stormy weather outside. We had a mix of experience in the group, but no complete novices, so the first session on the track was a free-for-all, for individuals to refamiliarise themselves with a fixed wheel and the wonderful track.

Next up, we worked as one group on single-lap changes on the black line, where the front rider does one lap, then pushes up the track to lose speed and drop back to the back of the group. No problems there.

After a short rest, we paired up to do some sprinting. We pedalled easy, spread around the track riding with our partners, then, at the blast of a whistle, we raced them to the finish line. Unfortunately, excitement was such that one couple slipped down before we even got started, and later another rider sprinted over the finish line and then forgot the golden rule for track riding- never stop pedalling! 2 more down! Lessons learned, and no damage done, except to pride.

The riders were still competitive and keen to show their colours, so we finished with a timed individual flying lap. The fastest was unsurprisingly the young blood, but the elders showed their class.

In view of the number of riders, we had only one coach, but we usually have 2 coaches and can split the group, so that less confident riders do not have to ride with the more competitive.

Please contact me if you are interested in coming to a session but have some barrier or anxiety that has prevented you from taking part in the past. Family members (over 12) can join in.

Thanks to the riders who supported this event.

By Barbara Wiles

track@sanfairyanncc.co.uk

SFA APP



Fairies Little Helper

If you don't already know, one of our members, **Mark Phillipson**, created an app that gives you quick, easy access to all the information on the Club website.

It's called **Fairies Little Helper**, and you can find all the download instructions here: Home - FairiesLittleHelper

We'd like to say a big **thank you to Mark for giving his time and skills to create something that makes life easier for other Club members.** It's a great example of how a little time given by one member can benefit the whole Club.

A little reminder about the ride polls



If you're planning to come on a club ride, please put yourself on the poll, even if you're not 100% certain. If something crops up on the day, you can always take yourself off. It really does make a difference. Without an accurate idea of numbers, our ride leaders are left trying to arrange extra leaders at short notice, and cafes need to be booked without knowing how many people are actually coming.

So please, if you're thinking of riding, put your name on the poll. It takes seconds, and it makes a big difference to the volunteers organising the ride.

Garmin Emergency Contact: Do you have yours set up?



Many of you will be aware that my husband, Jonathan Leeson, had a serious fall from his bike during an SFA ride. It was very fortunate that Jonathan was with other riders, who called for an ambulance and stayed with him throughout. I am so grateful to those Fairies.

I found out about the incident immediately when a message came up on my phone telling me, 'Jonathan Leeson's Garmin device detected an incident. You are listed as an assistance contact'. The message also included the incident coordinates.

Hopefully I am preaching to the converted and most of you already have 'Assistance Contacts' set up on your Garmin account. If you don't have it set up, as I hadn't at the time, the process is extremely easy and takes only a few minutes. As Jonathan's incident showed, the process works and could be essential if you are riding on your own. The steps to follow for Garmin are shown below. I assume other devices will have a similar function.

Setting Up Assistance in the Garmin Connect App

1. Open the Garmin Connect app.

2. Select More (bottom right).

3. Select Safety & Tracking.

4. Select Safety Features.

5. If prompted, agree to the Privacy Policy.

6. Under the section ‘Your Emergency Info & Contacts’, select My Information and input your information

7. Select the back option.

8. Select Assistance Contacts.

9. Select Add Assistance Contact. You can select up to 3 assistance contacts

10. Select from the list displayed. If your emergency contact is not listed, select Phone or Create a Connect Contact.

11. Check contact information for each contact added by selecting them from the list. Select the method of contact information displayed to edit a contact.

12. Select Send Request.

o This will open your phone's messaging app. You can send a message to your contact, where they can opt in to receive text messages from Garmin for the Assistance feature.

o Your emergency contact must accept this request in order to be successfully added.

13. Once finished, use the back option to exit this menu option.

By Sarah Leeson

Welcome to SFA.

Sallie Williams

Simon Charlesworth

Member Contributions

Here's a version that keeps the friendly tone while adding the practical requests:

A Reminder!

This newsletter is at its best when it includes **your** stories, not just mine.

If you've:

🚴 Been on a club ride

☕ Discovered a great café (or a terrible one…)

📍 Found a cracking route

📸 Taken some photos worth sharing

…then please send it in!

It doesn't have to be polished or poetic—a few lines are plenty. I can tidy it up if needed (that's my superpower).

One small favour: please send **the text and photos as separate files**, rather than as a finished page or layout. It makes it much easier for me to copy, edit and fit everything into the newsletter.

Also, please tell me **who's in the photos**, using **first and last names**, so I can give everyone the credit they deserve.

If you rode it, ate it, broke it, fixed it, or laughed about it afterwards, we'd love to hear about it.

Sharing is caring… and it saves me from having to make things up. 😄

Please send your articles and photos to Lorna via WhatsApp or email at membership@sanfairyanncc.co.uk.

Club Contacts

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